Epilogue: One Moment in Time

I was batting at Chelmsford, helping to set up the win against Warwickshire that took Essex to the top of the County Championship. It was a surreal, semi-detached experience. Like almost everyone in the ground on that Sunday afternoon, I had half an eye on the historic drama unfolding forty-five miles away, at Lord's.

Every couple of overs, the umpires quietly updated us on England's run chase in the World Cup final. Both teams were second guessing the significance of murmurs and exclamations from spectators. Attention wandered occasionally, to indistinct figures on a half-hidden TV screen in a hospitality area on the boundary. From the middle, I could not quite make out the score.

Once play had been completed for the day, with me unbeaten on 34 and Matt Quinn, our Kiwi night watchman, yet to get off the mark, we jostled for position in front of the set in the home dressing room. Ben Stokes and Jos Buttler were yet to reach their half centuries; even amongst experienced pros, the tension was palpable.

The sense of anticipation was so gripping I did not take my pads off until the super over was confirmed. The changing area was alive with conjecture; the tenor of texts grew in intensity as the countdown entered a critical phase. As I reflected, in a message to Michael, my collaborator on this book, 'Only sport can do this.'

At its best, sport sucks people in. It has a strange gravitational pull. I was not quite on the outside looking in, since I was watching friends and former